

Session 5: The Peacemakers and the Persecuted

Key Takeaways

- Peacemakers work towards *shalom* (“wholeness”) by seeking reconciliation between parties in conflict.
- Those who follow Jesus and work towards making peace can expect persecution.
- Jesus likens his followers to salt: preserving, flavoring, and purifying the world around them.
- Jesus casts a vision for a kingdom where those who are normally left outside and those who typically do the excluding come together to live by a new set of values, becoming an example of God’s goodness for the world—a city on a hill.

Salt, Light, City

Salt

13 **Y’all** are **the salt** of the land.

But if **the salt** loses flavor/is foolish,
with what can it be **made salty** again?

It’s useful for **nothing** (οὐδέν),
except to be thrown out and stepped on **by people**.

Light and City

14 **Y’all** are **the light** of the world.

It is not (οὐ) able to be hidden, **a city** that is set up on a mountain,
15 and they **don’t** (οὐδὲ) light **a candle** (λύχνον) and place it under a basket.
Rather, upon a **candle-stand** (λυχνίαν),
and it **will shine** on everyone in the house.

16 In the same way, **let your light shine** before people,
so that they can see **your** good works,
and so they can give honor to **your** Father who is **in the skies**

These two short parables are parallel addresses to Jesus' audience of disciples. If the Beatitudes described the surprising and ideal character of Jesus' Kingdom community, he now moves on to talk about the role of this community among Israel.

There is an important link back to the Beatitudes, which all begin with the phrase, "Flourishing are those who/the one who ..." but only the last beatitude shifts to, "Flourishing are you all who are persecuted."

This establishes a close connection between the warning of persecution and these two parables about the role of Jesus' community in the world. They are, as it were, explaining why his followers must go out into a world where they will be resisted and persecuted. It's because their role is to be salt, light, and a city.

He uses three metaphors, bound up in two parables: salt, light, and a city.

Salt of the Land

Davies and Allison surveyed the entire history of interpretation of this verse, and collected 11 different interpretations.

"As to what is meant in this passage by salt, the options are many. The following considerations are pertinent.

1. In Lev. 2:13 and Ezek. 43:24 salt is prescribed as an element to be added to sacrifices (cf. Ezra 6:9; Jub. 21:11; 11QTemple 20; m. Mid. 5:3).
2. In Num. 18:19 and Lev. 2:13 the 'salt of the covenant' is mentioned (cf. 2 Chr. 13:5; Jub. 21:11; 11QTemple 20:13; Sipra on Num. 18:19).
3. In 2 Kgs. 2:19-22 Elisha performs a miracle and uses salt in order to purify bad drinking water. The connexion between salt and purity is also found in Exod. 30:35 (the salt mixed with incense is called 'pure and holy') and perhaps Ezek. 16:4 (where infants are rubbed with salt; cf. b. Šabb. 129b).
4. In Job 6:6 salt is a condiment for food (cf. Plutarch, De garrul. 23, 514-15; Col. 4:6; b. Ber. 34a).
5. In Ignatius, Magn. 10 salt is a preservative. Compare Diogenes Laertius 8:1:35: salt 'should be brought to table to remind us of what is right; for salt preserves whatever it finds, and it arises from the purest sources, sun and sea'. Note also b. Ketub. 66b and ARN 17: 'the salt of money' is 'diminution' (that is, charity preserves wealth).
6. In Ecclus 39:26 we find this: 'Basic to all the needs of man's life are water and fire and iron and salt ...'. Compare Pliny, Nat. hist. 31:102: 'there is nothing more useful than salt and sunshine' (cf. 31:88). In these two texts salt is a necessity.
7. In Ezra 4:14 those who eat the salt of the palace cannot be witnesses against the king. To eat salt with someone is therefore a sign of loyalty (cf. the 'salt of the covenant').
8. In Mk. 9:50 salt is linked with peace: 'Have salt in yourselves and be at peace with one another'. Salt and friendship are also associated in Philo, Som. 2:210.
9. Col. 4:6 reads: 'Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer every one'.
10. In rabbinic texts salt is sometimes associated with wisdom, as in m. Soṭa 9:15: 'the wisdom of the scribes will become insipid'.

11. In the Greek tradition salt is 'beloved of the gods' (Homer, Il. 9:214; Plato, Tim. 60E) and often spoken of as being the 'spice' (= wit) of conversation (Plutarch, Mor. 514 F; Dio Chrysostom, Or. 18:13)."
Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 472-473.

These interpretations can be summarized as ...

1. Salt as a preservative is associated with endurance over time. Salt as a symbol of endurance explains the phrase "the salt of the covenant" ([Lev. 2:13](#); [Num. 18:19](#); [2 Chron. 13:5](#)), i.e., a covenant that endures.
2. Salt as a flavor-enhancing seasoning (see [Job 6:6](#); [Col. 4:6](#), "let your speech be seasoned with salt").
3. Salt as a purifying agent: Salt could be used to purify water ([2 Kgs. 2:21](#)), or to wash blood from a newborn ([Ezek. 16:4](#)), or to ensure the purity of something, like the holy incense used in the tabernacle ([Exod. 30:35](#)).

The problem: Salt had many symbolic associations in the ancient world, so how do we know which nuance Jesus is activating here?

The interpretation that takes the 1st century Jewish setting most seriously, and takes the key Hebrew Bible hyperlinks in [Matthew 5:13-16](#) into consideration has been summarized well by Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing*, p. 162-168; and Charles Quarles, *the Sermon on the Mount*, p. 77-83.

Jesus doesn't simply use the salt metaphor here, here uses three parallel images that are mutually illuminating:

- Salt of the land
- Light of the world
- City on a mountain

These three images are not random, but part of a dense network of scriptural images at work in the book of Isaiah's portrait of the new covenant people of God who carry on the work of "God's servant."

Light & City

Light is a key metaphor in Isaiah, drawn from day one in [Genesis 1:3-6](#), as an image of God's deliverance and new-creation power released into the world through God's appointed representatives. Israel was called to become a city through which God's light would shine into the world.

Isaiah 2:2-5 NASB

Now it will come about that in the last days
the mountain of the house of the LORD
will be established as the chief of the mountains,
and will **be raised above the hills**;
and all the nations will stream to it.
And many peoples will come and say,
"Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob;
that he may teach us concerning his ways

and that we may walk in his paths.”

For the law will go forth from Zion

and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.

And he will judge between the nations,

and will render decisions for many peoples;

and they will hammer their swords into plowshares and their spears into pruning hooks.

Nation will not lift up sword against nation,

and never again will they learn war.

Come, house of Jacob, and let us walk in the light of the LORD.

This image develops as Israel fails to be this light and city on the hill, and so God appoints a “servant” who will be this on his people’s behalf and thus fulfill God’s covenant promises.

Isaiah 42:6-7 NASB

I am the LORD, I have called you in righteousness,

I will also hold you by the hand and watch over you,

and I will make you a covenant of the people,

as a light to the nations,

to open blind eyes,

to bring out prisoners from the dungeon

and those who dwell in darkness from the prison.

Isaiah 49:5-6, 8 NASB

⁵ And now says the LORD, who formed me from the womb to be his servant,

to bring Jacob back to him, so that Israel might be gathered to him

(For I am honored in the sight of the LORD,

and my God is my strength),

⁶ he says, “It is too small a thing that you should be my servant

to raise up the tribes of Jacob and to restore the preserved ones of Israel;

I will also make you a light of the nations

so that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth.”

⁸ Thus says the LORD, “In a favorable time I have answered you,

and in a day of salvation I have helped you;

and I will keep you and **give you for a covenant of the people,**

to restore the land, to make them inherit the desolate heritages;

This theme culminates in Isaiah 60, where the new Jerusalem is a community of people who follow the servant and participate in his new covenant witness to the nations.

Isaiah 60:1-3 NASB

Arise, shine; for your **light** has come,

and the glory of the LORD has risen upon you.

For behold, darkness will cover the earth

and deep darkness the peoples;

but the LORD will rise upon you
and his glory will appear upon you.

Nations will come to your light,
and kings to the brightness of your rising.

Isaiah 60:14 NASB

The sons of those who afflicted you will come bowing to you,
and all those who despised you will bow themselves at the soles of your feet;
and they will call you the city of the LORD,
the Zion of the Holy One of Israel.

So what does any of this have to do with salt? Salt was involved in the traditional ways to enact a covenant ceremony, including Israel's sacrifices that reinforced their covenant bond with Yahweh.

Leviticus 2:13 NASB

Every grain offering of yours, moreover, **you shall season with salt**, so that the salt of the covenant of your God shall not be lacking from your grain offering; **with all your offerings you shall offer salt.**

Numbers 18:19 NASB

All the offerings of the holy gifts, which the sons of Israel offer to the LORD, I have given to you and your sons and your daughters with you, as a perpetual allotment. It is **an everlasting covenant of salt before the LORD** to you and your descendants with you.

2 Chronicles 13:4-5 NASB

Then Abijah stood on Mount Zemaraim, which is in the hill country of Ephraim, and said, "Listen to me, Jeroboam and all Israel: Do you not know that the LORD God of Israel gave the rule over Israel forever to David and **his sons by a covenant of salt?**"

Notice how this last passage in 2 Chronicles 13 takes up the theme of God's eternal promise to the house of David (see 2 Sam. 7; Ps. 89, 132) but describes it in the language of Numbers 18:19. In other words, this shows how the Chronicler sees salt as a metaphor for "enduring" or "eternal" which makes it an apt image for describing God's covenant promise to David of an eternal messianic kingdom from his lineage.

Jesus is bringing together all of the key themes of the Torah and Prophets regarding Israel's role among the nations. Israel was called to be the kingdom of priests, in eternal covenant with Yahweh, so that through them the Eden blessing could spread out to all of the nations (Gen. 12:1-5; Exod. 19:4-6).

The prophets, specifically Isaiah, developed the imagery describing Israel's vocational calling into an image of a glorious heaven-on-earth city on top of a tall hill, shining divine light out to the nations who would come and learn God's wisdom, resulting in a new era of peace, and of the worship of Yahweh.

Notice how the final line, "so they will see your good works and glorify your father in heaven" (Matt. 5:16), takes up the images from Isaiah and Jeremiah about the new Jerusalem as the site of an international pilgrimage where the nations worship and give glory to Yahweh.

Isaiah 40:4-5 NASB

Let every valley be lifted up,
and every mountain and hill be made low;
and let the rough ground become a plain,
and the rugged terrain a broad valley;
**then the glory of the LORD will be revealed,
and all flesh will see it together;**
for the mouth of the LORD has spoken.

Isaiah 52:9–10 NASB

Break forth, shout joyfully together,
you waste places of Jerusalem;
for the LORD has comforted his people,
he has redeemed Jerusalem.
The LORD has bared his holy arm
in the sight of all the nations,
**that all the ends of the earth may see
the salvation of our God.**

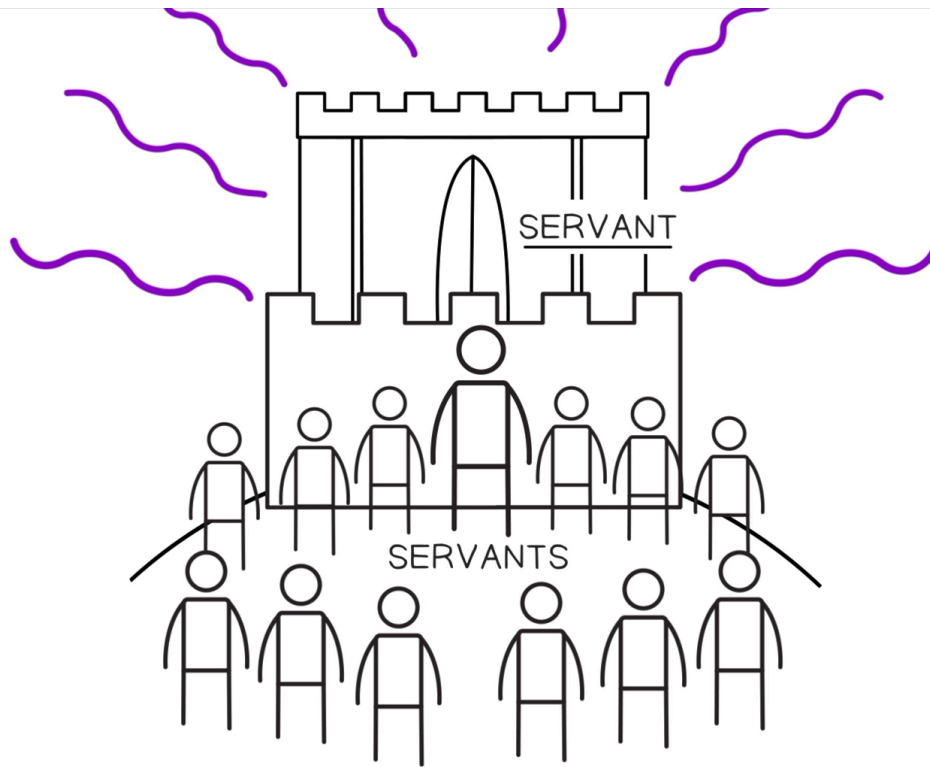
Isaiah 66:18–19 NASB

For I know their works and their thoughts; **the time is coming to gather all nations and tongues.**
And they shall come and **see my glory.**
I will set a sign among them and will send survivors from them to the nations: Tarshish, Put, Lud, Meshech,
Tubal and Javan, to the distant coastlands that have neither heard my fame nor **seen my glory.**
And they will declare my glory among the nations.

“Taken together, the salt and light metaphors, with the flavors of Isaiah everywhere, result in a clear and powerful statement about the future new covenant coming through Jesus. This combination of metaphors ... evokes the biblical storyline and hope for the new covenant time when God will return and bring his comfort throughout the world. Jesus is the great prophet and suffering servant of Isaiah, bringing light and grace to the world. By extension, then, Jesus’ disciples are likewise heralds of this new covenant message ... and they embody this ‘salt and light’ effectiveness through good works that are visible and bring honor to their and Jesus’ heavenly Father.”

Pennington, Jonathan T. (2017). [*The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing: A Theological Commentary*](#). Baker Academic. 165-167.

The Servants as the City



The Servants as the City. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Reflection Question

What does it mean for Jesus to call his followers “the salt of the earth”?